

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 8
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Truth Telling
26 July 2026

Updated LVF 10:00am
COMMUNION
NEO Voice Festival Choir

Michael away

Preaching: LVF
Worship Leading: Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack & Meg Russett

Organ Prelude-Concert

Improvisation

Sandra ?, Cathedral Choir Member

Everything is Immanent – Jason Olshan

Air – Saginaw Rozzo

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Alleluyas – Simon Preston

Sienna Stribling, *2026 N.E.O. Organ Fellow*

Chiming of the Hour

[Chad and Meg to center chancel]

Welcome

CTP

Words of Gathering

MR & CTP

MR: As we greet this new day, let us gather our love and courage,
because we can do hard things:

Brave things

Beautiful things

Risky and transformative things.

CTP: The Sacred always journeys with us
toward freedom:

For the sake of the collective life

*For the sake of disrupting evil
For the sake of the human soul.*

MR: In this, our time and place:
*We are called and accompanied.
We are never alone.*

So, in this time set apart -
may our hearts be encouraged
for all that lies before us.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

[adpt/enfleshedmjadekaiser]

CTP: *Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn Of Gathering**

Gather Us In

 **Gather Us In - Process Hymn**

Here in this place new light is streaming,
Shadows of doubt are vanished away.
See in this space our fears and our dreamings,
Brought here to you in the light of this day.
Gather us in, the lost and forsaken;
Gather us in; our spirits in flame.
Call to us now, and we shall awaken;
We shall arise at the sound of our name.

We are the young, our lives are a mystery;
We are the old, who yearn for your face.
We have been sung throughout all of history,
Called to be light to the whole human race.
Gather us in, the rich and the haughty;
Gather us in, the proud and the strong;
Give us a heart so meek and so lowly;
Give us the courage to enter the song.

Here we receive new life in the waters;
Here we receive the bread of new birth;
Here you shall **call all of your children**
Call us anew to be salt for the earth.
Give us to drink the wine of compassion,
Give us to eat the bread that is you;
Nourish us well, and teach us to fashion
Lives that are holy and hearts that are true.

Not just in buildings, small and confining,
Not in some heaven light years away,
here in this place the new light is shining;
Now is God present, and, now is the day.
Gather us in and hold us forever;
Gather us in and make us your own;
Gather us in, all peoples together,
Fire of love in our flesh and our bone.

[Chad center chancel]

Prayer of Confession & Awareness

CTP

God of freedom and liberation,
you have given **us the laws of love**, spoken through prophets,
and provided us with the Spirit to help guide us
in love and justice.
Still we struggle.

*The complexities of life and the challenges of
being human often win over.
In our pain, we do harm one another,
we do not intervene when our neighbors are targeted,
and we become possessive of power and resources.*

Yet you do not leave us where we are.
You call us to a new way of life and you ask us
to make your dream for this world a reality.

*Forgive us, O God, where we have failed
and surround us with your never ending love and hope,
as you ground our lives in mutual care and connection.*

*We pray this with gratitude for your love and grace and mercy.
Amen and Amen!*

[All turn towards choir]

Introit

“Analogy of Being” part III
N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

Fahad Siadat

[Meg to lectern]

***The Lord’s Prayer**

MR

Let us pray together this reimagined Lord’s Prayer...

*Creator of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.
May your dreams of justice, love, compassion, and
connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourished
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys and
liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power-over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.
All praise to you, our comfort and our strength.
Amen and Amen!*

[enfleshed/adpt/lvf]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Chad center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

When we become cognizant of the fact that our everyday
experiences and our gradual becoming
unfolds at a pace that can't be corralled in by clock time,
then we can accept that slowing down and being present
with the season of life that we are flowing through,
is necessary.

Even the steps that seem unnecessary, become a part
of the sacred practice of loving where we are -
and we find peace...in this moment and time.

[adpt/enfleshed]

This morning,
May this Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

CTP

Please be seated

[Meg to lectern]

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

from the Prophet Amos

MR

Listen with your whole hearts to this ancient text from the Book of Amos
[Bold and bright]

"But let justice roll on like a river, righteousness like a never-failing stream!"

This is the simple and complex wisdom of the ancestors.
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph transition Chad to center chancel]

Prayers with the People

CTP

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

We are inseparable from generations past
and generations future.

The lives of the ones who came before us
are present all around us.

The needs of those to come...call upon us today.

What are we doing with all we have inherited -
the wonderful and the terrible?
What will we leave behind?

May the Holy things, the righteous things,
the things that make us brave in spirit
and fierce in hope
be our source of wisdom and guidance
as we strive to live faithfully
to the Sacred
to each other
to those past and yet come
in these days we have been given.

Let us now be in silence together...

[2 minutes Abe transition out of silence]

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of sleeping and waking,
in every state of our being, be near.

In our dreams, invite us to your creative vision of what could be:
of who we could become and what we could create together.
Nourish our imagination with glimpses of justice
that is full and healing that is rich.

In our waking up, may we do so with acceptance
of the day that closed, and embrace the day that is opening.
May your lovingkindness guide us in both accountability
to our friends, neighbors, and beloveds
and in grace that keeps us from being weighed down
by that which we can no longer control.

When we long to sleep but find ourselves awake
in the middle of the night, wrestling with the world,
our past, our future, or anxieties that do not yet
have names, may your Spirit of Peace embrace us.

When we struggle to stay awake - bone tired, soul heavy -
longing for the relief that is too far off, uphold us.

And then, O God, as we move through these cycles of rest and labor,
when they are balanced just right
and when they are all out of whack, be the constant
source that guides our life in peace, courage,
and the assurance of your hope for us.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

[Abe transition for choir]

Meditation Anthem

“There Is Light”

Clara Moniz

N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

*“There is silence now where there once was colour There is light In place of fear There is space
where life was full and love replacing emptiness Hollow space overflowing The overflow and the
flood Overflowing Love” ~Clara Moniz*

[Abe transition Laura to pulpit]

Sermon

Truth Telling

LVF

[Abe transition as Chad & Laura go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings

LVF & CTP

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

LVF: We give thanks for the invitation to be at this table,
for here we are shown our lives...

CTP: The daily bread of work and care,
the cup of delight, pressed from the fruits of creativity
and our brokenness, with all its pain and self-knowledge.

LVF: We celebrate the life that is ours
for we know we are precious in your sight.
We celebrate the life that is yours,
which has become a pattern of reality for us:
It is as this love is revealed,
given and received
that we are able to put love into action.

We give thanks for the Spirit of New Life
active in our lives
as it was in the life of Jesus.

CTP: At this gathering in this sacred place
we take bread as Jesus took bread,
and we remember as Jesus remembered,
the constant presence
of the Spirit of Life and Love.

We break and share this bread
as Jesus broke and shared it.

We share this bread as our pledge of openness
to the Spirit in our midst,
and in acknowledgement
of our eternal connectedness with the Spirit of Life.

LVF: We take this fruit of the vine and pour it as Jesus poured it.

We drink as Jesus invited the friends to drink,
mindful of the relationship of love and trust
between ourselves and the Spirit of Life,
believing as Jesus believed,
that beyond pain and shadows and death,
life in the Spirit continues
in ways beyond our imagining.

Prayer of Blessing

Amen and Amen.

LVF: This table is for all, whether you have a lot of faith, etc....

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

[Meg to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

MR

In this community we gather together each week because we share with God, a vision. It includes the belovedness of every one of us but it is also much bigger than any single life. We recognize and know deep within our lives, that the Kingdom of God is a collective reality.

Each week, we are invited to share from our resources for the work we have been called to, together.

Offertory

"I've Learned To Sing"

Sam Scheibe

N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

*"I've learned to sing a song of hope, I've said goodbye to despair;
I caught the note in a thrush's throat, I sang---and the world was fair!
I've learned to sing a song of joy It bends the skies to me,
The song of joy is the song of hope Grown to maturity.
I've learned to laugh away my tears As through the dark I go
For love and laughter conquer fears My heart has come to know.
I've learned a song of happiness It is a song of love For love alone is happiness
And happiness is love." ~Georgia Douglass Johnson*

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Meg to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering**

MR

Please join us in this Prayer of Offering:

*God of justice, your compassion and courage sustains us,
And your graciousness gives us hope.*

*Use us and these gifts to further your way
Of love, hope, and justice.
Amen and Amen! Please be seated.*

[Laura & Chad center chancel]

Life at First Church

LVF & CTP

LVF: Next week, our summer series, *Another Kind of Freedom*, continues with the theme, *Radical Love*. We also bid farewell to David Harris and Laurel Irene as they move their family to Oregon. Our service will feature lots of music and then we'll share a special Coffee Hour in their honor. We're also excited to have Dr. Abraham Ross as our guest organist again next week. Thank you, Abe!

CTP: Summer Clothing Drive is ongoing- bring new or gently used summer clothing items to the security booth anytime! We'll share those with our neighbors as part of Food@First on Sunday, Aug. 16.

LVF: Sunday, Aug. 9, our LGBTQ+ group here is hosting another Book Launch following the service in Shatto Chapel. And our Community Collaborative is hosting a Summer Picnic in the Amanda Scott Gardens on Saturday, Aug. 29th!

CTP: The NEO Voice Festival is in residence at FCCLA this week. Their new ExplOratorio will premiere this Friday, July 31st. Laurel Irene will also perform a special concert this Wednesday, July 29th, a retrospective of her time here in LA. Tickets for all of these concerts are on the Resonance Collective website, and you can get free tickets by using the code: FCCLA.

LVF: Join us for Coffee Hour today following the Service!

Words of Blessing

LVF

For freedom,
Christ has set us free!
No longer bound by fear;
Not tempted towards
destruction!
Love is our salvation and
justice is our cause.
With the Spirit as our guide,
We shall not be moved.
-enfleshed

Choral Response

“Ka Sise Fun Iwenumo Emi Wa”

Yoruba hymn, arr. Damilola Odebiyi

N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

“In vanity we hope after worldly promises that vanish. Let us join together to bring about the beloved community of the divine. God has promised the fruits of these labors. Amen!”

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn for the Journey**

Let Justice Like Water

ST DENIO

Let justice like waters roll down on our land;
Help us O Christ Jesus, to join in your plan.
Let righteousness like ever flowing streams rise;
Come, fill and anoint us, O Spirit most wise.

Pure wisdom and justice flow forth from your hand;
With you as our guide evil forces disband.
Give us, O Christ Jesus, the grace to prevail
O'er systems and powers that keep captives held.

O may we flow freely like waters and streams;
To heal and restore broken hearts and lost dreams.
Awaken us fully to all we can be,
Reclaiming our souls as we set people free.

Let justice like waters roll down on our land;
Help us O Christ Jesus, to join in your plan.
Let righteousness like ever flowing streams rise;
Come, fill and anoint us, O Spirit most wise.
[lyrics adapted from Jann Aldredge-Clanton]

[Chad center chancel to say: please be seated for the postlude]

Postlude

Improvisation

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Inside The Music

The N.E.O. Voice Festival is here and with it artists from around the world seeking the wonders of N.E.O.'s compassion-filled approach to the voice and creativity. We are all grateful to FCCLA for getting to be a part of this community! Please join us on Wednesday 7/29 at 7:00 for Laurel's concert with Abe, and Friday 7/31 for the ExplOratorio premiere "At The End Of All Things" where we will present the concert-length piece we'll create this week.

The neuroscientist and author of “How Emotions Are Made”, Lisa Feldman-Barrett, explains that scientists have shown since the 1970 that functionally, truth is what we make it. That clear statement yields deep complexity, since we also feel truth as an essential and guiding principal in our lives. Today’s music explores the growing edges of truth and how we come to understand and create with it. I’ve wanted to sing Fahad’s “Analogy of Being” for years. Today we’ll sing only the last movement. He found the text on a blackboard in a Pasadena church. It’s an exploration of Thomas Aquinas, and it all fits our theological space so adroitly. He uses the concept of semantic satiation as its core. Through repetition, the words begin to lose their meaning and we release into the wonder of their essence. Harmonically he floats a D in the sopranos over an Eb and C minor chord respectively giving the words “creator, sustainer, redeemer” and extra transformative power. Sam’s setting of Georgia Douglass Johnson “I’ve Learned To Sing” rests at the heart of the truths we learn to tell ourselves. Douglass Johnson was a Harlem Renaissance playwright and poet who broke new ground as one of the first widely recognized women with this distinction. Sam’s lilting, folk-inspired melody flows with the ease of the words. The poem reveals traumas behind its brightness. She explains how she chose to not let those traumas define her existence, but rather, found ways of defining life through truths that more accurately reflected the life she wanted to inhabit. The piece was originally written for younger voices, and Sam added some to the score for us making this a premiere performance. “Ka Sise Fun Iwenumo Emi” is a well known Nigerian hymn sung at celebrations as a community statement of faith and perseverance. Dami’s setting will be a premiere performance. I am excited to welcome Dami into our space. We have premiered two of his choral/organ pieces in the past. His presence represents a perseverance of its own, and his determination to be physically present with this community, having been with us virtually from Nigeria many times. We’ll only sing the last verse of his hymn setting today, and we’ll premiere his newest work on Friday at the culmination of the N.E.O Festival. Like his other pieces, “Ka Sise” rings with full timbral bliss. The Nigerian choral tradition has a long and glorious group singing history. I love listening into Dami’s music to hear the sonorities embedded in his experience.

Clara’s “There Is Light” was the first choral piece she wrote. We are a coveted second performance. She uses sustained textures punctuated with text phrases to bring out the suspended, transformative energy of the text. She says of the piece that: “There Is Light” was inspired by coming of age and leaving behind some of the irrational worries of childhood. It explores the bittersweetness of losing the naivety that shapes a child’s worldview while offering a hopeful look towards the future, as this innocence gives way to a deeper love and appreciation for those around you. The idea of ‘light’ present throughout the work represents love in many forms, the discovery of passions, and newfound freedom. The chords in the opening figure evoke the image of light rising over the horizon signaling new beginnings. This work is dedicated to friends, mentors, and most importantly all the wonderful people I get to make music with.